C1 Speaking

Handling difficult questions

Buy time, clarify, and answer tough questions in interviews, exams and meetings without losing control.

Difficult questions are not a test of instant knowledge; they test how calmly you respond. A few prepared phrases let you think, clarify and give a structured answer.

Strategy	Phrases
Buying time	*That's a good question. Let me think about that for a moment.*
Clarifying	*Do you mean... or...? Could you say a bit more about what you mean by...?*
Rephrasing	*So, if I understand correctly, you're asking whether...*
Partial answer	*I can't speak for the whole department, but in my team...*
Admitting you don't know	*I don't have the exact figure, but I can find out and get back to you.*
Structuring	*There are two sides to this. On the one hand... On the other...*

Repeat the question in your own words. It buys you thinking time and checks that you are answering what was actually asked.

Common mistake. Filling silence with *umm... err... like...* or guessing a fact. A short, honest *I'm not sure, but...* sounds far more professional.

Practice

Write what you would say.

1. An interviewer asks "What is your biggest weakness?" Buy a few seconds.
2. Someone asks "How do you feel about the changes?" but you are not sure which changes they mean.

3. Someone asks for this year's exact sales figure and you don't know it.
4. Rephrase to check: "Isn't remote work bad for teamwork?"
5. Begin a balanced answer to "Should exams be replaced by projects?"

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. That's a good question. Let me think about that for a moment.
2. Do you mean the new schedule or the new management structure?
3. I don't have the exact figure with me, but I can check and get back to you today.
4. So, if I understand correctly, you're asking whether working from home makes it harder for teams to work together?
5. There are two sides to this. On the one hand, projects show real skills; on the other, exams are fairer to compare.